

Who pays when a delivery fails

SPRINT COURIERS · DELIVERY PROJECT · FAULT MODEL



Brick 15. Drafted 12 September 2026 by Luther Roberts. **Status: proposed. Not yet agreed by Barbara.**

Every rule below is a default that operates unless someone overrides it in writing. Where a rule needs a number that only finance can set, the number is marked as such rather than invented.

WHY THIS EXISTS BEFORE THE APP TAKES A CENT

The council said, independently and twice, that paying merchants the same day is impossible without this. That is right, and the reason is simple. The moment money moves automatically, somebody has to have already decided who carries the loss when a delivery goes wrong. If that decision is made afterwards, order by order, by whoever is on the phone, then three things follow. Merchants stop trusting the settlement. Riders learn which failures to hide. And nobody can tell whether the business makes money, because the losses never land anywhere you can count them.

The order state machine already refuses to move an order into any failure path without a fault attached. This document says what the fault means in money.

THE FOUR FAULTS, IN PLAIN WORDS

Fault	Means
Merchant	The shop could not supply what was sold, or supplied it wrong, or kept the rider waiting past the agreed time
Customer	The address was wrong, nobody was there, or the person refused or failed the identity check
Rider	The rider abandoned the job, was late through their own doing, damaged or lost the goods
Sprint	No rider was available, the app failed, dispatch sent it wrong, or the company simply could not do what it sold
None	Nobody is at fault. Flood, accident that was not the rider's doing, roadblock, power cut, a death in the family

None is a real answer and it must stay easy to choose. If the only options blame somebody, people pick the nearest person, and the numbers become fiction.

THE TABLE

Four things can move when an order fails: the goods, the delivery fee the customer paid, what the rider is paid, and who carries the cost of taking goods back.

What went wrong	Fault	Goods	Delivery fee	Rider paid	Return leg	Customer is told
Shop cannot supply, before a rider is assigned	Merchant	Refunded in full	Refunded in full	Not applicable	None	The shop cannot supply this, your money is coming back
Out of stock, customer takes a substitute	Merchant	Difference settled either way	Charged as normal	Paid in full	None	We swapped one item, here is the difference
Out of stock, customer drops the item	Merchant	That line refunded	Charged as normal	Paid in full	None	One item was not available, the rest is on its way

What went wrong	Fault	Goods	Delivery fee	Rider paid	Return leg	Customer is told
Out of stock, customer cancels the order	Merchant	Refunded in full	Refunded in full	Paid in full	Merchant	Sorry, the shop let us down, everything is coming back
Rider abandons after accepting	Rider	Unaffected	Unaffected	Not paid for that job	Sprint	Nothing. Reassigned before they notice
No rider available at all	Sprint	Refunded in full	Refunded in full	Not applicable	Sprint	We could not get anyone to you, your money is coming back
Wrong address, sorted out, delivered late	Customer	Charged as normal	Charged as normal	Paid, plus the waiting time	None	Nothing
Wrong address, cannot be found, goods returned	Customer	Refunded less any perishable loss	Not refunded	Paid in full	Customer	We could not find the address, the delivery fee stands
Nobody home after the agreed wait	Customer	Refunded less any perishable loss	Not refunded	Paid in full	Customer	We waited and could not reach you, the delivery fee stands
Identity check failed, liquor or prescription	Customer	Refunded less any dispensing cost	Not refunded	Paid in full	Customer	We cannot hand this over without the right identification
Rider breaks down, goods returned	None or Rider	Refunded in full	Refunded in full	Paid if none, not paid if the rider's own doing	Sprint	Something happened on the road, your money is coming back
Goods damaged in transit	Rider	Refunded in full	Refunded in full	Paid, and it goes on their record	Sprint	We damaged it, your money is coming back
Customer cancels after paying, before pickup	Customer	Refunded in full	Refunded in full	Paid if already travelling	None	Cancelled, your money is coming back
Customer cancels after pickup	Customer	Refunded less perishable loss	Not refunded	Paid in full	Customer	Cancelled after it left the shop, the delivery fee stands
Dispute after delivery, upheld	Depends	Refunded	Refunded	Paid in full	Case by case	Sorry, your money is coming back
Dispute after delivery, not upheld	None	Not refunded	Not refunded	Paid in full	None	We looked at the proof of delivery and cannot refund this one

THE FIVE RULES UNDERNEATH THE TABLE

1. The rider is paid unless the rider caused it. This is the most important line in the document. A rider who loses a morning's pay because a shop was out of stock or a customer was not home will start refusing hard jobs, avoiding far addresses, and hiding failures rather than reporting them. Paying them protects the data as much as the person.

2. Fault is recorded by the person who was there, at the time. The rider at the door, the shop when it rejects the order. Not by operations the next morning from memory. The app asks at the moment of the event and will not proceed without an answer.

3. Small losses are written off, not argued. Below a threshold that finance sets, the loss is absorbed and the order is closed. Arguing over forty pula costs more than forty pula in staff time and in goodwill. **Threshold: to be set by finance.**

4. Perishables and prescriptions cannot go back on a shelf. A returned frozen basket or a dispensed prescription is a real loss to the merchant or the pharmacy, not a restock. Those returns are settled at cost, and the customer whose fault it was is told that before they order, not after.

5. Any fault can be appealed once, within seven days, to one named person. Not a committee, not a form. **Who: to be named by Barbara.** A rider or a merchant who believes a fault was wrongly assigned says so and one person decides. Without an appeal route, fault assignment becomes something people work around.

WHAT THIS MAKES POSSIBLE

Same day merchant settlement becomes arithmetic rather than a judgement call. At the end of each day every completed order has a fault of merchant, customer, sprint, rider or none already attached, so the payout file can be produced without anyone reading an order history.

It also makes two director questions answerable for the first time. **Failures per rider, by fault**, which says who is actually struggling rather than who complains loudest. And **failures per merchant, by fault**, which says which shop is quietly costing money through stock it does not have. Both come free once fault is recorded at the moment it happens.

THE THREE NUMBERS BARBARA AND FINANCE MUST SET

1. The write off threshold in rule 3.
2. The waiting time at the door before a customer counts as absent. A number, in minutes, the same for everybody.
3. Whether a rider who is not paid for an abandoned job still keeps that day's other earnings, which is an employment question and not a delivery one.

WHAT IS NOT SETTLED

- - **MyZaka has no automatic settlement to a bank account.** Their own contract has the merchant emptying an electronic wallet by hand. So even with this model agreed, same day payment on that rail must be funded from Sprint's own account and reconciled afterwards. Not solved here, and it belongs with brick 19.
- - The appeal person is not named.
- - Nobody has decided what happens on the second and third time a rider causes the same failure. That is a people question and it belongs with the rider model at brick 36.
- - This model assumes Sprint carries the goods. It says nothing about a merchant who delivers with their own driver on our platform, which will come up the moment a supermarket signs.

AGREEMENT

This becomes the operating rule when Barbara agrees it, and not before. Until then the app records fault correctly and nothing is deducted from anybody.

Agreed by: _____ Date: _____